

A SOVEREO INTELLIGENCE BRIEF

Before You Go

The clear-eyed briefing for Americans weighing the most consequential, and least reversible, decision of their adult life.



Moving abroad has never been easier to research, or harder to get right.

More Americans are leaving the United States than at almost any point in living memory. If you are weighing it, you are not alone, and you are not foolish. The trouble is that more information has not made anyone decide better. The feeds are full of highlight reels: a rooftop in Medellin, cheap rent in Lisbon, a beach in Playa del Carmen. What they do not give you is judgment, and that missing judgment is where people lose years, savings, relationships, and sometimes their legal standing.

This brief does two things. First, it shows you what is actually happening, with current data on the movement you are part of, so you can see it plainly. Second, it shows you the standard a relocation decision deserves, and how few in this market meet it. If you finish it wanting serious eyes on your own situation, you will know where to find them. If you decide you can do this alone, you will at least do it better. Either way you come out ahead, which is the point.

It is free, and it asks nothing of you but the time to read it. Everything it points to, the daily intelligence and the instrument that turns it into a decision, is built to be useful long before it ever asks you to buy anything.

The people who do this well are not the boldest. They are the ones who treated the move as the serious financial and legal decision it is, ran it with discipline, and kept their options open until the facts were in. That is the whole of this brief: the data to see the moment clearly, and a standard worthy of the stakes.

The migration is real, and it has changed

For decades, "I am moving to Canada" was something Americans said after an election and never did. That era is over. The talk has turned into measurable movement, and the movement is now documented.

180k

US CITIZENS WHO EMIGRATED IN 2025, THE LARGEST OUTBOUND FLOW IN DECADES, BY SOME COUNTS THE HIGHEST SINCE THE GREAT DEPRESSION. (GLOBAL CITIZEN SOLUTIONS)

~40%

WOMEN UNDER 45 WHO WOULD MOVE ABROAD PERMANENTLY IF THEY COULD, ROUGHLY FOUR TIMES THE 2014 SHARE. (GALLUP, 2025)

5.5M

AMERICANS ESTIMATED TO LIVE ABROAD ALREADY, A POPULATION THE GOVERNMENT DOES NOT FORMALLY TRACK. (AARO, 2024)

Who is leaving has changed, and this is the part that matters. When the Americans heading abroad were seasoned international operators, they brought their own judgment with them. That has changed. The people leaving now are ordinary: retirees stretching fixed incomes, remote workers whose dollars travel further, families citing safety, and people leaving for personal or political reasons. By Gallup's data, the desire is concentrated among women, younger Americans, and lower-income groups. The number of Americans renouncing citizenship tells the same story: a few hundred a year before 2009, and roughly five thousand in 2025.

So the skill a move now requires has gone up while the experience of the average mover has gone down. That combination produces expensive, foreseeable mistakes. And the country people dream about is rarely the one that fits their life. Most who talk about it name Portugal. Most who actually move stay closer to home: Mexico and Canada hold the largest American populations abroad, well over a million between them.

The trap: why most relocation decisions fail

A move abroad is not one decision. It is a stack of them: legal, financial, medical, family, and cultural. Each can fail on its own, and most are difficult or impossible to reverse. The hype economy treats the whole thing as a single emotional leap, and that is where people get hurt. The failures we see most often are almost never the ones people worry about in advance.

01 The tax trap

Most movers do not realize that immigration status and tax status are two different things, or that crossing a day-count threshold can expose their entire worldwide income to a second tax authority. They learn it when it arrives as a bill instead of a plan.

02 The qualification gap

People fall in love with a country before checking whether they can legally stay in it: income thresholds, savings that must be aged and proven, documentation. A plan built on a country you cannot qualify for collapses late, and expensively.

03 The titling and asset error

Property bought in the wrong structure, in the wrong name, or under a legal system the buyer never understood, then lost when a relationship, a partner, or a local court did not behave the way the buyer assumed it would.

04 The currency and cost illusion

The highlight reel shows the rent. It hides healthcare, visa renewals, import costs, and the exchange-rate risk of earning in one currency while living in another.

05 Collapsing three decisions into one

The most dangerous move of all is treating a relationship, a relocation, and a major financial commitment as one impulsive decision, on a timeline set by feeling rather than diligence. Each one deserves its own evaluation. Folded together, they tend to fail together.

06 Confusing a vacation with a life

The two-week trip that felt like paradise tells you almost nothing about the twenty-year reality. Tourism and residency are different experiences under different rules, and that difference has ended more relocations than any visa office ever has.

The common thread is not bad luck. It is low information meeting high stakes with no decision discipline in between. The cost gets measured in years and in money, and nearly all of it is foreseeable. Which raises the only useful question: what would it look like to do this with the discipline it deserves?

Seven questions to answer before you go

If you do nothing else this brief asks, sit with these seven. Each turns one of the failures above into a question you can actually answer. A move with clean answers to all seven rests on diligence, not feeling.

01 Tax residency

Where will you be a tax resident, and where will your income be taxed? Learn the day-count thresholds before you book a flight, not after.

02 Qualification

Can you actually qualify for the visa you want? Confirm the income floor, the savings you must show, and how long the money must be seasoned.

03 Title and structure

Whose name holds the property, under which structure, and how would a local court treat it if a relationship or a partner changed?

04 True cost

What is the all-in monthly cost in your spending currency, once healthcare, renewals, import costs, and exchange-rate risk are added to the rent?

05 Three decisions, not one

Have you separated the relationship, the relocation, and the financial commitment into three evaluations rather than one impulsive leap?

06 Lived, not visited

Have you spent a low season on the ground, not a vacation, before signing anything you cannot easily undo?

07 The exit

How would you leave, recover your capital, and re-establish at home if the move does not hold? A plan with no exit is a trap with a view.

The person who sees the picture
early has time to build around it.
The person who waits finds the
gaps the day they break.

SOVEREO · DECISION INTEGRITY

A different standard: Decision Integrity

The fix is not more information. You can already get all the information you want, and that is the problem. The fix is judgment: a disciplined way to turn the available facts into one clean, defensible decision built around your actual life. That discipline is what Sovereo calls Decision Integrity. A few principles set it apart from the rest of this market.

It evaluates your decision, not the country.

No country is simply "best." A place that is paradise for a remote-earning thirty-eight-year-old can be a trap for a retiree on a fixed income. The universal "best countries" ranking, the format the whole industry runs on, is the wrong tool. The real question is always this: best for whom, and solving what.

It is independent.

This is the part the market cannot easily offer you. Most of the well-known names make their money brokering the move itself: the residency, the citizenship deal, the real estate, the referral. When a firm's revenue depends on you relocating, its advice cannot honestly tell you to wait, to choose elsewhere, or to stay home. Sovereo brokers none of it, which is what allows it to give you the most valuable answers in this field, including the answer that you should stay where you are.

It accounts for the full life, not just the tax bill.

A real evaluation weighs the things that actually make a life good: income and cost, education, healthcare, lifestyle, and legacy, along with the things most analysts treat as unmeasurable, like the political, social, cultural, and religious environment your family will live inside. None of these has a universal ranking, which is why they should be weighted to your values rather than scored on someone else's scale.

It is honest about decay and the limits of knowledge.

Conditions change. Thresholds rise, tax regimes close, security shifts. A report that does not date its own assumptions is misleading the day it is published. And in a world where anyone can generate a confident-sounding dossier about a country they have never visited, being honest about what can and cannot be known from a distance is its own discipline. You get told the confidence level instead of being sold false certainty.

Grounded in the science, built on the data

Decision Integrity is not an opinion dressed up as a method. It rests on research economists and epidemiologists have built for half a century, and on public data anyone can check.

The core finding is settled: **where you live is a social determinant of how long, how healthy, and how wealthy your life will be.** The evidence runs from the Whitehall studies of the British civil service to the World Health Organization's Commission on Social Determinants of Health. Sovereo turns that science into a decision you can act on, scoring all 195 countries on the six forces it identifies.

Income · Education · Health and Longevity · Environment · Belonging · Legacy and Sovereignty

Every score in the Sovereo Index is drawn from named, public datasets, not proprietary guesswork. Any number can be traced to its source.

UNDP

HUMAN DEVELOPMENT

World Bank

GOVERNANCE, PRICES

WHO

HEALTH SYSTEMS

Yale EPI

ENVIRONMENT

Heritage

ECONOMIC FREEDOM

EF

ENGLISH PROFICIENCY

V-Dem

GROUP EQUALITY

Gallup

MIGRANT ACCEPTANCE

Williams Institute

SOCIAL ACCEPTANCE

Decision Integrity is what happens when that evidence meets your life: the data, weighted to your values, with the confidence level shown rather than hidden.

Where to start

Everything Sovereio makes is built to the same standard. The three below are free and ask nothing of you. Begin here.

START FREE, TODAY

The SITREP

FREE • DAILY

The day's signals that move your money, your freedom, and where you can safely live, each traced to a primary source, in about sixty seconds. This is the front door. It reads the whole world, not just the Western wires.

Subscribe free at mail.sovereio.com

The Relocation Diagnostic

FREE • ON SOVEREIO.COM

A validated nine-module instrument that scores all 195 countries for your life and returns your three best-fit places, with the reason and the single biggest caveat for each. It evaluates your decision, not a generic ranking. Nothing is stored; it runs in your browser.

Take it at sovereio.com

The Sovereio Index

FREE • ON SOVEREIO.COM

All 195 countries scored on the six determinants of a long, healthy, wealthy life, from public data and the established science. The map of the world the diagnostic personalizes for you.

Explore it at sovereio.com

When the decision calls for more

Go further only when the move in front of you earns it. Each of these takes the same discipline one step closer to your own situation.

The Brief

PAID · WEEKLY

Where the SITREP exposes the signal, the Brief decides the move: the weekly analysis that names the mechanism and makes the call you can act on, written from a Global South vantage. Not opinion, not motivation. Rigorously sourced.

Subscribe at sovereobrief.substack.com

The Country Report

COMMISSIONED · BY INQUIRY

A dossier on your destination built for your exact profile: the residency and tax routes that apply to you, the costs, the timeline, the matrimonial and succession rules, and the on-the-ground reality, with a dated confidence level.

Inquire at sovereo@proton.me, subject Country Report

Private Advisory

BY INQUIRY

A confidential engagement for a high-stakes move: direct access to Sovereio's research and judgment, scoped to your situation, with the recommendation on the line. Not a sales call.

Inquire at sovereo@proton.me, subject Private Advisory

Serious counsel for a serious decision

Any American seriously weighing a life abroad: retirees, remote workers, families, entrepreneurs, and those leaving for reasons that are personal or political. The discipline is the same for everyone. Only the destination and the weighting change. It is built with particular depth for groups the market has underserved, including the fast-growing community of Black Americans building purposeful lives abroad, a movement rich in story and encouragement but thin on rigorous, independent counsel. Serious counsel does not require you to belong to any category. It only requires that you are making a real decision.

WHY THIS DESK

Sovereio was founded by Todd Allyn, a professor of business and economics for twenty-four years and former Dean of the College of Business at Chancellor University, where he helped build the Jack Welch School of Business. His teaching has reached from that US business school to students in China, and he now lives in Colombia with his family, having made the cross-border move himself and reading Latin America from the inside rather than from a flyover.

Colombia is the point, not a contradiction. It sits mid-pack on the objective Index, and he lives there on purpose, because a global ranking is never the answer to where one person should go. Weighted for his own life, family first, with portable income and the currency arbitrage that move makes possible, his diagnostic puts Colombia at the top. That is the whole thesis of Sovereio: the right country is not the top of a worldwide ranking, it is the top of yours. He built the instrument that proves it, then moved where it pointed.

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- Professor of business and economics, 24 years
 - Former Dean, College of Business, Chancellor University
 - Helped build the Jack Welch School of Business
 - Has taught economics to students in China
 - Lives in Colombia, having made the move himself

IF YOU ARE GOING TO MAKE THIS DECISION

Make it clean.

Start where it costs nothing. Read the SITREP for a week and watch how the world actually reaches your money and your options. Take the diagnostic and see your three countries. Then, if the move in front of you deserves it, go deeper.

You are holding proof of the standard. The daily SITREP brings it to you every morning, and this brief is the welcome. Begin there, and let the decision earn each step that follows.

START FREE, DAILY

[mail.sovereio.com](mailto:mail@sovereio.com)

YOUR THREE COUNTRIES

sovereio.com

THE WEEKLY BRIEF

sovereobrief.substack.com

REPORTS & ADVISORY

sovereio@proton.me

THINK CLEAR • DECIDE CLEAN • EXECUTE UNDER PRESSURE

This brief is decision intelligence, not legal, tax, immigration, medical, or investment advice. Residency, tax, and security conditions change and vary by individual circumstance; confirm current figures with the relevant authorities and a qualified cross-border professional before acting. Market figures cited are drawn from publicly reported data (Gallup, Pew Research Center, the Association of Americans Resident Overseas, and Global Citizen Solutions, 2024 to 2026) and carry the inherent uncertainty of a population the U.S. government does not formally track. The Sovereio Index and Relocation Diagnostic are educational research instruments built from public datasets. © 2026 Sovereio Intelligence Research. All rights reserved.